

ADMINISTRATIVE EVOLUTION

“From local authority to provincial governance.”

Administrative boundaries can change in a single document. Institutions take longer. And communities remember even longer. The history of Orakzai is therefore not only a history of territory; it is also a history of administration. Different generations encountered different systems of authority. Some knew local elders and jirga. Some encountered colonial frontier officials. Others lived under the Political Agent and the institutions of the former tribal-area administration. Later generations entered a political system increasingly connected to Pakistan’s constitutional and electoral institutions. And after 2018, Orakzai entered a new phase as part of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. The map changed. The laws changed. The institutions changed. But the community did not suddenly become something new.



“The layered evolution of administration in the Orakzai region.”

WHAT DOES ADMINISTRATIVE EVOLUTION MEAN?

Administrative evolution refers to the systematic changes in territorial organization, legal authority, and government institutions. It involves the shift from informal customary norms to formal state bureaucracies. For Orakzai, this meant moving from a system where authority was personal and kinship-based to one where it is institutional and district-based.^{1 8}

TERRITORY

+

LAW

+

INSTITUTIONS

+

SERVICES

=

ADMIN

“The logical components of an administrative system.”

STATE ADMINISTRATION

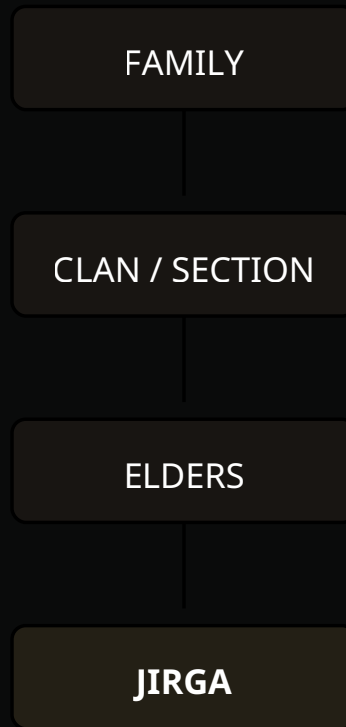
- Constitutional Status
- Provincial Departments
- Courts & Police
- District Management
- Land Records

SOCIAL IDENTITY

- Language (Pashto)
- Kinship & Family
- Tribal Lineage
- Customary Riwayaj
- Local Memory

BEFORE FORMAL AGENCY ADMINISTRATION

Before the modern bureaucratic state, authority in the Orakzai region was decentralized. It was not a single centralized government but a network of overlapping institutions. Authority resided in the family head, the clan elder, and the collective ****Jirga****. This pre-colonial system was based on ****Pashtunwali**** and local custom, where power was negotiated rather than dictated by a central office.⁹



“The conceptual hierarchy of customary authority.”

THE POLITICAL AGENCY SYSTEM (1973–2018)

The creation of Orakzai Agency in 1973 formalized a system of "indirect rule" that had its roots in colonial policy. The **Political Agent (PA)** was the pivot of this system, holding executive and judicial powers. The state communicated with the tribe through **Maliks** (recognized intermediaries), creating a special administrative space defined by the **Frontier Crimes Regulation (FCR)**.^{7 8}



“The administrative hierarchy of the former Political Agency system.”

AGENCY VS. DISTRICT: A FEATURE COMPARISON

The 2018 merger represented the most significant administrative shift in over a century. It replaced the FCR with the Constitution and provincial laws, and transitioned the region from a federally administered frontier to a provincial district.^{2 5}

FEATURE	AGENCY ERA (PRE-2018)	DISTRICT ERA (POST-2018)
Administrative Head	POLITICAL AGENT	DEPUTY COMMISSIONER
Legal Framework	Frontier Crimes Regulation (FCR)	Constitution / KP Provincial Laws
Judiciary	PA / Jirga (Administrative Justice)	District & Sessions Judge (Regular Courts)
Security / Police	Levies / Khasadars	KP Police
Representation	National Assembly / Senate	NA / Senate / KP Provincial Assembly

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

The history of Orakzai is a history of navigating different systems of power. Laws change in a day, but institutions take years to mature, and community memories last for generations. The shift from "ruling" a frontier through a Political Agent to "serving" a district through a Deputy Commissioner is the core challenge of the 2018 merger. Administrative lines do not define the Orakzai people; they only define how the state sees them. The true evolution is not just in the

documents of the secretariat, but in the ability of the community to ensure that constitutional integration translates into dignity, justice, and service for every citizen.

“ADMINISTRATION CHANGES. THE COMMUNITY ENDURES.”

ADMINISTRATIVE EVOLUTION ANALYSIS
